



USA and Belgium Win Gold as FIVB Beach Pro Tour Challenge 2026 Concludes at KIIT University

INTERNATIONAL BEACH VOLLEYBALL TOURNAMENT BRINGS TOGETHER 83 TEAMS FROM 52 COUNTRIES IN BHUBANESWAR, INDIA

The FIVB Volleyball World Beach Pro Tour Challenge 2026 concluded on 8 March 2026 at the Dutee Chand Athletic Stadium of KIIT Deemed to be University, Bhubaneswar, capping five days of international beach volleyball action featuring top teams from across the world.

The tournament, hosted by KIIT Deemed to be University, brought together 83 teams from 52 countries, with more than 300 players and officials participating in the championship. The event created a vibrant sporting atmosphere on the KIIT campus and attracted large numbers of spectators who witnessed high-level international competition.

In the Women's Gold Medal Match, the Japanese pair Shiba/Reika faced the United States duo Durish/Koenig. The American team demonstrated strong coordination and attacking play to secure a straight-set victory, winning 2-0 (21-18, 21-16) and claiming the gold medal. The Japanese pair finished with the silver medal after a competitive contest.

The much anticipated Men's Gold Medal Match featured Sepka/Dzavoronok of the Czech Republic against Vercauteren/Van Langendonck of Belgium. In a closely fought encounter, the Belgian team delivered a composed and skillful performance to win 2-0 (21-10, 22-20) and secure the championship title. The Czech team finished as runners-up with the silver medal.

The closing ceremony featured a welcome and congratulatory address by Prof. (Dr.) Achyuta Samanta, Founder of KIIT, KISS and KIMS, Board Member of the Strategic Council of the Volleyball Foundation (FIVB), Chief Patron of the Volleyball Federation of India, and President of the Odisha Volleyball Association. He congratulated the winning teams and appreciated the high standard of competition displayed throughout the tournament.

"All 300 players and officials were accommodated at KIIT Campus. We made a very good arrangement for their stay inside the campus. All of them were happy with KIIT's hospitality", Dr. Samanta said.

A message from His Excellency Dr. Hari Babu Kambhampati, Hon'ble Governor of Odisha, was shared during the ceremony. A video message from Shri Mansukh Laxmanbhai Mandaviya, Hon'ble Union Minister of Labour & Employment and Minister of Youth Affairs & Sports, Government of India, was also played, congratulating the organisers and participants for the successful

conduct of the prestigious international event.

Referees and officials associated with the tournament were felicitated in recognition of their contribution to the successful organisation of the championship.

The ceremony concluded with a vote of thanks by Prof. (Dr.) Saranjit Singh, Vice Chancellor of KIIT Deemed to be University, who expressed gratitude to the international teams, officials, organisers, volunteers and supporters who contributed to the success of the event.

KIIT University also achieved a significant milestone by becoming the first university in India to host an event of the FIVB Beach Pro Tour Challenge series. The tournament was formally inaugurated on March 4 by Shri Prithviraj Harichandan, Hon'ble Minister for Law, Works and Excise, Govt. of Odisha in the presence of international delegates and sports officials.

Players and officials praised the world-class sports infrastructure, professional organisation, and hospitality provided by KIIT University. Many participants noted the excellent accommodation, food arrangements and supportive environment created for athletes and officials.

The tournament concluded with enthusiastic applause from spectators, marking a memorable celebration of international beach volleyball at KIIT University in Bhubaneswar.

HIGHLIGHTS

- ▶ **KIIT University, became the first university in India to host an FIVB Beach Pro Tour Challenge event.**
- ▶ **The event was held for five days at Dutee Chand Athletic Stadium in Bhubaneswar.**
- ▶ **The tournament featured 83 teams from 52 countries.**
- ▶ **International players and officials praised the world-class Infrastructure, organisation and hospitality provided by KIIT University.**
- ▶ **More than 300 players and officials participated in the championship.**